



ROBOTICS



OpenMind wants to be the Android operating system of humanoid robots

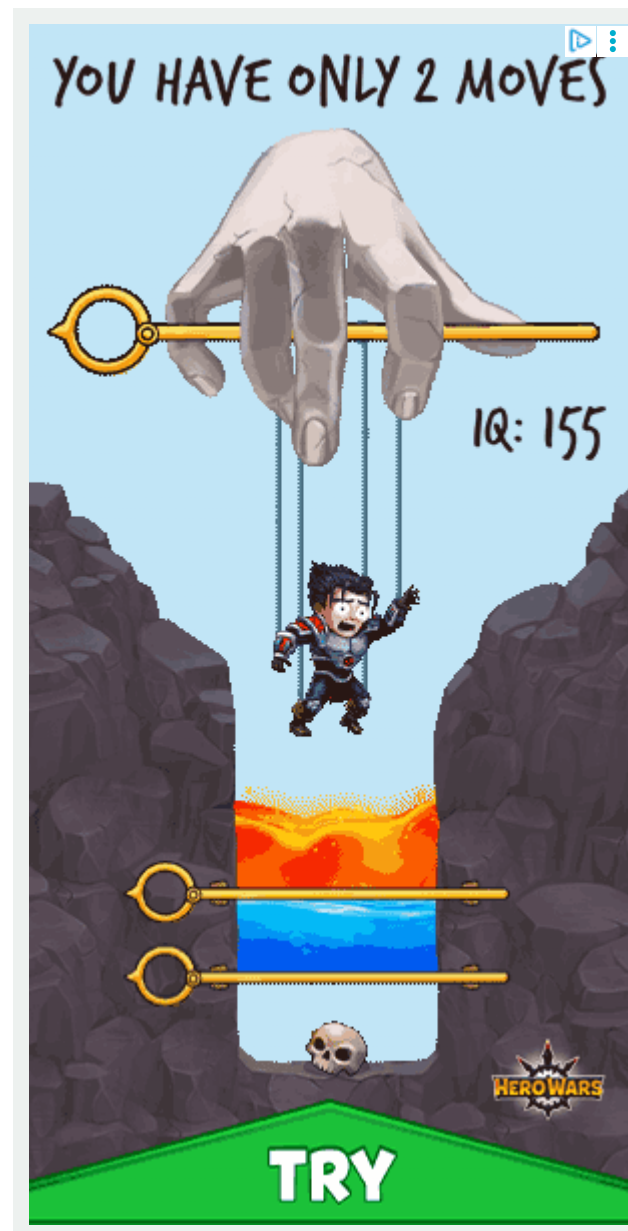
Many companies are focused on building robots, or the hardware components to help them move, grip objects or interact with the world around them. Silicon Valley-based OpenMind is focused under the hood.

OpenMind is building a software layer, OM1, for humanoid robots that acts as an operating system. The company compares itself to being the Android for robotics because its software is open and hardware agnostic.

Stanford professor Jan Liphardt, the founder of OpenMind, told TechCrunch that humanoids and other robots have been around and able to do repetitive tasks for decades. But now that humanoids are being developed for use cases that require more human-to-machine interactions, like having a humanoid in your home, they need a new operating system that thinks more like a human.

“All of a sudden, this world is opening where machines are able to interact with humans in ways I’ve certainly never before seen,” Liphardt said. “We’re very much believers here that it’s not just about the humans, but we really think of ourselves as a company that is a collaboration between machines and humans.”

OpenMind unveiled on Monday a new protocol called FABRIC that allows robots to verify identity



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and share context and information with other robots.

Unlike humans, machines can learn almost instantly, Liphardt said, which means giving them a better way to connect to other robots will allow them to more easily train and absorb new information.

Liphardt gave the example of languages and how robots could connect to each other and share data on how to speak different languages, which would help them better interact with more people without having to be taught each language by a human directly.

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“Humans take it for granted that they can interact with any other human on Earth,” Liphardt said. “Humans have built a lot of infrastructure around us that allows us to trust other people, call them, text them, and interact and coordinate and do things together. Machines, of course, are going to be no different.”

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OpenMind was founded in 2024 and is gearing up to ship its first fleet of 10 OM1-powered robotic dogs by September. Liphardt said that he's a big believer in getting the tech out there and iterating on it after the fact.

"We full well expect all the humans that will be hosting these quadrupeds, they'll come back with a long list of things they didn't like or they want, and then it's up to us to very, very quickly iterate and improve the machines," he said.

The company also recently raised a \$20 million funding round led by Pantera Capital, with participation from Ribbit, Coinbase Ventures, and Pebblebed, among other strategic investors and angel investors.

Now, the company is focused on getting its tech into people's homes and starting to iterate on the product.

"The most important thing for us is to get robots out there and to get feedback," Liphardt said. "Our goal as a company is to do as many of these tests as we can, so that we can very rapidly identify the most interesting opportunities where the capabilities of the robots today are optimally matched against what humans are looking for."

Topics: [AI](#) [artificial intelligence](#) [Exclusive](#)

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Rebecca Szkutak

Senior Reporter, Venture | [in](#)

Becca is a senior writer at TechCrunch that covers venture capital trends and startups. She previously covered the...

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AI



Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

Aisha Malik — 11:18 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS:

MATTHIAS BALK/PICTURE ALLIANCE / GETTY IMAGES

As the new school year approaches, Google [announced](#) on Wednesday that it's launching a new tool called Guided Learning within Gemini. The tool sort of functions like an AI tutor, as it's designed to

help users build a deep understanding instead of just getting answers.

The launch follows just over a week after OpenAI rolled out [Study Mode for ChatGPT](#), which is also designed to go beyond simply obtaining answers to questions by actually helping users develop critical thinking skills.

Both companies’ launches [come amid concerns](#) that AI chatbots [undermine the learning process](#) because they spit out direct answers. The new tools from Google and OpenAI likely aim to address these concerns by positioning their chatbots as learning tools rather than simple answer engines.

With Guided Learning, Gemini will break down problems step-by-step and adapt explanations to its users’ needs. The feature responds using images, diagrams, videos, and interactive quizzes to help users build and test themselves on their knowledge, rather than simply giving them the answer.

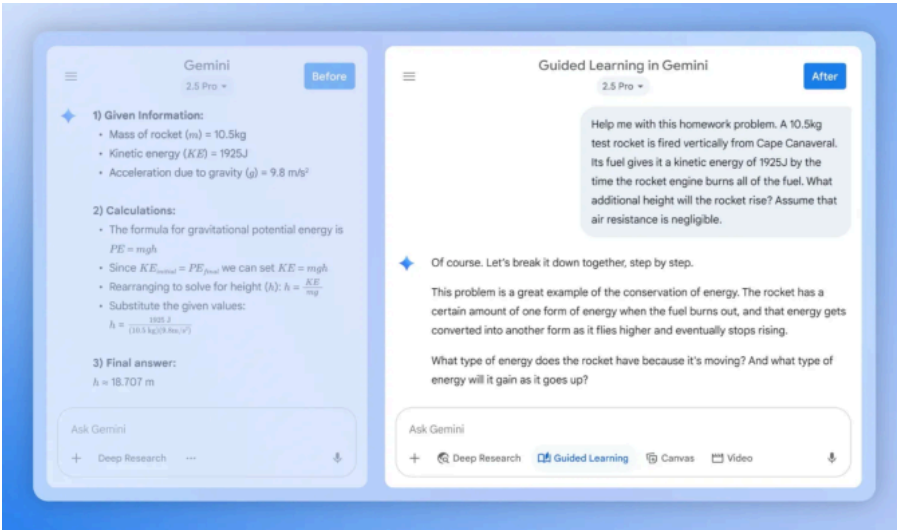


IMAGE CREDITS:GOOGLE

Google says the feature will help users uncover the “why” and “how” behind concepts.

“Whether you’re preparing for an exam about enzymes, starting the first draft of a paper on the importance of bee populations in supporting our

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food systems, or exploring your passion for photography, Guided Learning is a collaborative thinking partner that helps you get it — each step of the way,” wrote Maureen Heymans, Google’s VP of Learning & Sustainability, in the [blog post](#).

In addition to the new feature, Google announced that it’s working to make Gemini as a whole better equipped to help users learn. Gemini will now automatically incorporate images, diagrams, and YouTube videos directly into responses to help users better understand complex topics. Plus, users can now also ask Gemini to create flashcards and study guides based on their quiz results or other class materials.

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Google also announced on Wednesday that it’s offering students in the U.S., Japan, Indonesia, Korea, and Brazil a free one-year subscription to Google’s AI Pro plan.

The plan includes expanded access to [Gemini 2.5 Pro](#), [NotebookLM](#), [Veo 3](#), [Deep Research](#), and more.



Aisha Malik

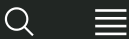
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Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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into corporate staffing beyond freelancers

Rebecca Szkutak — 1:05 PM PDT · August 6, 2025

[Upwork](#), a platform that connects companies with freelancers, announced two acquisitions to help build out a new stand-alone enterprise-focused business that could expand its market reach.

The San Francisco-based company announced it has acquired [Bubty](#), a workforce management platform, and has signed a definitive agreement to acquire [Ascen](#), a global compliance and EOR (employer of record) company, ahead of its second-quarter earnings call on August 6.

Upwork will integrate these two companies into its existing enterprise business to create a stand-alone entity under the Upwork umbrella.

The move is significant because it will allow Upwork to offer access to talent beyond the independent contractor workforce Upwork is known for — essentially enabling the company to compete in new areas of the corporate staffing market. The new entity will support contract types, including agent of record, employer of record, and staff augmentation.

Upwork president and CEO Hayden Brown told TechCrunch that the timing was right to launch this new enterprise-focused business because Upwork's existing enterprise customers have been increasingly asking for access to these talent pools.

"Most of the providers that exist today force their customers to choose between flexibility and compliance, or speed and scale, or having a digital tool versus having something that's actually robust and for the enterprise," Brown said. "And with this

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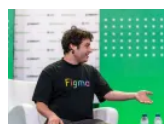
ENTERPRISE



Upwork is buying its way into corporate staffing beyond freelancers

Rebecca Szkutak
- 22 hours ago

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Rebecca Bellan - 1 day ago

new capability, we're refusing to compromise. We're giving our customers all of the benefits they've been looking for, and we've heard loud and clear that they want this singular solution."

Brown said that Upwork's existing enterprise business makes up about \$100 million of the company's overall \$750 million in yearly revenue.

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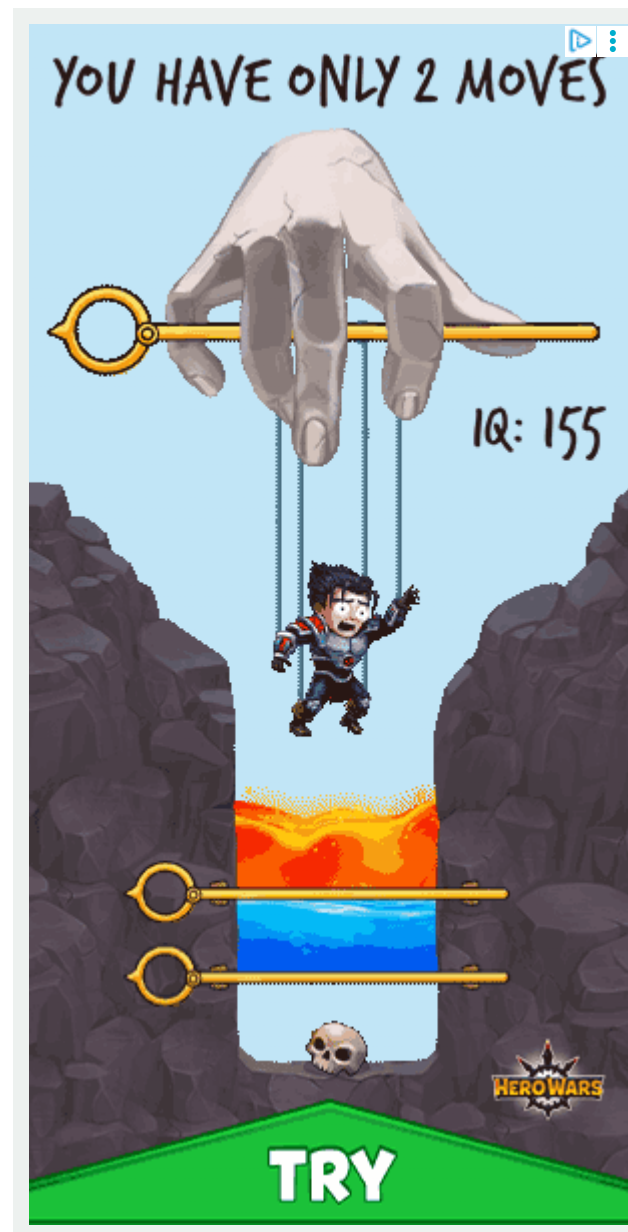
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Upwork decided to make the enterprise business a stand-alone entity because enterprises have very different needs regarding compliance and software integrations than the small and midsize businesses Upwork's main business works with.

Keeping them separate allows for better external branding and better internal focus, Brown said.

Upwork vetted more than 100 potential companies to acquire to build out this business, Brown said. The company landed on Bubtly and Ascen not only for what they bring separately but also for how they



worked together — Upwork piloted the companies both individually and together.

“We saw through the power of those pilots how impactful their technology was and how easy it was to basically snap together what each of them offers, along with our existing offering to deliver something very new and innovative in the market,” Brown added.

Details on the branding and full offerings of the new stand-alone business are set to be unveiled later this year.

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Google's AI coding agent Jules is now out of beta

Jagmeet Singh — 9:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Google on Wednesday launched its AI coding agent, Jules, out of beta, just over two months after its [public preview debut in May](#).

Powered by Gemini 2.5 Pro, Jules is an asynchronous, agent-based coding tool that integrates with GitHub, clones codebases into Google Cloud virtual machines, and uses AI to fix or update code while developers focus on other tasks.

Google [initially announced](#) Jules as a Google Labs project in December and made it [available to beta testers](#) through a public preview at its I/O developer conference.

Kathy Korevec, director of product at Google Labs, told TechCrunch that the tool's improved stability drove the decision to take it out of beta after receiving hundreds of UI and quality updates during its beta phase.

"The trajectory of where we're going gives us a lot of confidence that Jules is around and going to be around for the long haul," she said.

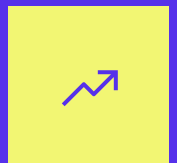
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With the wider rollout, Google introduced structured pricing tiers for Jules, starting with an “introductory access” free plan capped at 15 individual daily tasks and three concurrent ones, down from the 60-task limit during beta. Jules’ paid tiers are part of the Google AI Pro and Ultra plans, which are priced at \$19.99 and \$124.99 a month, and offer subscribers 5x and 20x higher limits, respectively.

Korevec noted that Jules’ packaging and pricing are based on “real usage” insights gathered over the past couple of months.

“The 60-task cap helped us study how developers use Jules and gave us the information we needed to design the new packaging,” she said. “The 15/day is designed to give people a sense of whether Jules will work for them on real project tasks.”

Google also updated Jules’ privacy policy to be more explicit about how it trains AI. If a repository is public, its data may be used for training, but if it is private, Korevec said that no data is sent.

“We got a little bit of feedback from users that it [the privacy policy] wasn’t as clear as we thought it was, and so most of it is just responding to that. We didn’t change anything about what we’re doing on the training side, but we changed the language,” Korevec said.

During the beta, Google said that thousands of developers tackled tens of thousands of tasks, resulting in over 140,000 code improvements shared publicly. Initial feedback led the Google Labs team to add new capabilities, including reusing previous setups for faster task execution, integrating with GitHub issues, and supporting multimodal input.

the exit door

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Publish branch

Publish branch with your changes

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Publish branch and generate PR



IMAGE CREDITS: JULES / X

The two primary users of Jules so far are the AI enthusiasts and professional developers, Korevec said.

By running asynchronously in a virtual machine, Jules stands apart from top AI coding tools like Cursor, Windsurf, and Lovable, which all work synchronously and require users to watch the output after each prompt.

“Jules operates like an extra set of hands ... you can basically kick off tasks to it, and then you could close your computer and walk away from it if you want and then come back hours later. Jules would have those tasks done for you, versus if you were doing that with a local agent or using a synchronous agent, you would be bound to that session,” Korevec explained.

This week, Jules received a deeper integration with GitHub to [open pull requests automatically](#) — just like it could open branches — and a feature called [Environment Snapshots](#) to save dependencies and install scripts as a snapshot for faster, more consistent task execution.

From vibe coding to mobile use, beta trials informed Jules’ development

Since entering public beta, Jules has logged 2.28 million visits worldwide, 45% of them from mobile devices, per data from market intelligence provider [SimilarWeb](#), reviewed by TechCrunch. India was the top market for traffic, followed by the U.S. and Vietnam.

Google did not share specifics on Jules' user base and its top geographies.

Korevec told TechCrunch that during the beta, the team observed that many people used Jules from traditional vibe-coding tools to either fix bugs that might have been implemented or extend the vibe-coded project to make it more production-ready.

Originally, Jules required users to have an existing codebase. But Google soon realized many potential users — like those trying other AI tools — might want to explore it without one. Korevec said the company quickly enabled Jules to work even with an empty repository. That helped increase its scope and usage.

Google Labs' team also noticed an increasing number of users accessing Jules through their mobile devices. Although the tool does not have a dedicated mobile app, Korevec said users were accessing it through its web app.

“Since it’s a big use case that we’re seeing emerging, we’re absolutely exploring what the features are that people need on mobile a lot more,” she noted.

Alongside beta testers, Korevec stated that Google already uses Jules to help develop some projects internally, and there is now a “big push” to use the tool on “a lot more projects” at the company.

Topics: [AI](#) [Google](#) [Google Jules](#) [jules](#)



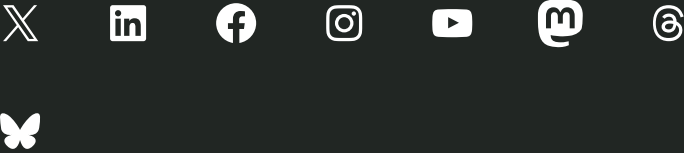
Jagmeet Singh

Reporter |

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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